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Enabling Access to Confidential Qualitative Data through Data Enclaves

International Secure Data Facility Professionals Network (ISDFPN) Meeting

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Secure qual data? Great idea….

- Because anonymization/any data alteration often destroys essential value of data for research
- Oh, but on second thought…

Workflow 1: Accepting data into a TRE

- Need criteria, but not hard to make a start
  - Identifiers, sensitive content, reuse potential
- But do not seem to be many new barriers
- Possible problems with scale and dynamic data, e.g., social media, smart meters (but not unique to qual data…)

Workflow 2: Setting up Virtual Work Spaces

- Mostly OK, but high volumes could mean slow processing time for users
- Need to install qual software tools (e.g., NVivo)
  - Not cheap, there are many, and host institutions will often NOT already have licenses
  - And some require internet connectivity
  - But…could restrict to 1-2 packages to start
  - Consult experts at CAQDAS (Computer Assisted Qualitative Data Analysis) U Surrey

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Workflow 3: Output Disclosure Control (ODC)

"perchance to dream: ay, there's the rub!"

- The challenges may seem insuperable
  - No (few) rules for anonymizing compared with quant (ONS has ODC done by people who are not methods experts)
  - With qual, range of methods even greater than in quant (at least vis-à-vis problem disclosure)
  - Biggest problem is context as disclosure risk – location of pub in Northern Ireland
  - But we should not give up quite yet!

When it looks tough, redefine the problem

- Typically, very small amounts of data published – selected quotes
  - Really good news, as quantity of work needed is low
- Do not forget that both closeness to, and distance from, data are valuable in assessing risk ("Four Eyes")
- But do seem to need contextual info to do this safely…how to get it?
- Best short-term options
  - Check with PIs or participants for approval - partial, but not always feasible, and not LT solution
  - Or to other individuals or institutions that they delegate.

Scaling a Solution

- Practical steps to consider
  - Start with guidance for quant and looking if they fit qual. Not exact match, but if the underlying principles work, e.g., *Confidentiality and Disclosure Risk: the UK Data Service Approach (public version?)*
  - Privacy Impact Assessment Guidance (EU) https://gdpr.eu/wp-content/uploads/2019/03/dpia-template-v1.pdf

- Build frameworks - by methods and data type
- Establish pool of qualified checkers-no one institution can have sufficient breadth of expertise

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One lesson from history and practical next step

- In late 1990s, integration of qual data into a survey-centric data archives also seemed insuperable
- Archives did not believe it would be feasible to adapt systems built for quant to incorporate quali, but they have
- Qualidata was established as part of UK Data Service in 2003
- Key lessons: find high-value dataset (*The Edwardians* Oral History project) and a widely respected senior researcher (now, perhaps Jane Elliott and *National Child Development Survey*?)
- Next : Workshop to refine and improve this proposal, with your additions please!

"What hath quenched them hath given me fire."

Thanks to…

- Elizabeth Green, et al. **What are the output disclosure control issues associated with qualitative data?**

  https://blogs.uwe.ac.uk/dragon/what-are-the-output-disclosure-control-issues-associated-with-qualitative-data/
- Debs Wiltshire
- Cristina Magder and Sharon Bolten (UKDS)

Thank you for your attention

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